WILDLIFE IN FOCUS XIII

PHOTOS OF THE DIVERSITY OF WILDLIFE AND HABITATS ON TEXAS PRIVATE LANDS

Vermillion Flycatcher

A08-2-066

WILDLIFE IN FOCUS

XIII

2025

Texas Community, Creativity, and Conservation

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ABOUT THE CONTEST

The Photography Contest is a statewide Texas event that sits at the heart of Wildlife in Focus mission and philosophy. The initiative brings together landowners and nature photographers into a pictorial celebration of the Texas natural environment, a means to encourage conservation through partnership, education, and creativity. Through this collaboration, participants play a vital role in documenting to preserve wildlife, habitats, and landscapes that define the natural heritage of Texas.

The contest images represent the mission's core. Without wildlife and wildscapes, there would be nothing to protect and nothing to preserve for future generations to learn from and cherish. Wildlife in Focus could not fulfill its potential or its educational goals without documenting the wildlife and the habitats of Texas in all its splendor. The photography book is the not-for-profit organization's face and remains as its most valuable teaching, outreach, and recruitment tool. The Wildlife in Focus portfolio reminds us why we celebrate conservation while renewing OUR resolve to make sure these efforts are not lost for the next generation. For these reasons, the pages within this photography book must evolve and remain relevant to environmental conditions changing and conservation needs.

Like nature itself, the photography book necessarily reflects beauty, tenderness, cruelty, resilience, and essence for all of Texas's wild places. To keep that impact, we need photographers who cherish wildlife and natural habitats as much as our organization does. Keeping these breathtaking images fresh, we must collaborate with an ever-changing pool of talented landowners, whom are gatekeepers of new landscapes.

We feel competition is the best way to achieve a high level of creativity and innovation our environment demands and our patrons deserve.

This is why we staged the contest. And so it is with any tournament, there are tiers of winners and champions crowned. Each year, five grand prize winners are named based on a graduated scoring system in a wide range of categories within five divisions of birds, mammals, invertebrates, reptiles and amphibians, and special division. There is no single grand prize photo. But there is a first-place winner in each category. The highest-scoring contestants overall are honored as the first grand prize winners for displaying consistent quality throughout a body of work across many divisions.

By design, our nature photographers are more than skilled technicians. We challenge them to collaborate with their landowner teammates, to maximize the most potential from a property, and to document wildlife with responsibility and safety. They must become nature detectives. Those who are not biologists must become quick studies in animal behavior and wildlife conditioning, not to mention meteorology, and first aid. Rarely are winners simply lucky. They must be willing to endure bites and stings, heat, and thorns, all while managing fears and phobias to stay focused. Most of all, we expect our talented photographers to exercise a level of creativity that tops their past efforts to produce more captivating images than those found in previous Wildlife in Focus volumes.

It takes more than a bird on a stick to wow this audience. We are never disappointed.

THE OJECTIVES

To promote wildlife and habitat conservation in Texas, we have designed a four-part program

The Mission

Wildlife in Focus is a not-for-profit organization that uses world class photography to inspire, educate, and connect people to nature with the purpose of protecting and preserving native Texas wildlife and habitats. To set this initiative in motion, Wildlife in Focus strategically partners with the business community and collaborates with Texas landowners and photographers through the photo competition. We have developed a four-part program to support this mission.

The Photography Contest

Pairing photographers with landowners who share a conservation goal remains a key component of the Wildlife in Focus photo competition. They each pay a fee to compete and share equally in the prize money awarded. This partnership is essential to the success of the contest. Capturing award-winning images depends not only on technical skill, but also on building a strong understanding of the ranch's habitat, its wildlife, and the working relationships with those who manage and protect these natural resources. Striking this balance produces meaningful results that highlight both the beauty and the fragility of our natural environment in Texas.

The Photography Book

Each book showcases winning images from the most recent photo contest. These world-class photography books feature a wide range of species birds, mammals, insects, arachnids, reptiles and amphibians, along with stunning landscapes, sunrises, and sunsets. The books capture an intimate and artistic view of wildlife as seen through the eyes of photographers, allowing readers to see beyond the ranch gates of Texas where our precious wildlife coexists in a habitat with humans. When landowners accept the Wildlife in Focus challenge, they agree to open their property gates to their talented photographer teammates and the thousands of folks who view the captivating pages of the Wildlife in Focus library. This unlimited access to ranch wildlife and habitat is our way of showcasing Texas' natural glory statewide so others may understand why it's important to maintain and cherish our natural world.

The Photo Exhibit

To expand its reach and educational objectives, Wildlife in Focus is on the road year-round, bringing award-winning photography to communities throughout Texas. This traveling exhibit is displayed at museums, banks, schools, art centers, and festivals. A permanent display is featured on the walls of Corpus Christi International Airport. Have you seen it?

Kritters 4 Kids

Education is a major component of the Wildlife in Focus non-profit mission. Kritters 4 Kids is an environmental educational program for students in elementary and middle schools. Thousands of Wildlife in Focus books are in hundreds of classrooms, helping teach children about Texas wildlife and landscapes. For many students, these books provide a captivating first glimpse of the flora and fauna that exist in habitats beyond their own backyards.

Wildlife in Focus depends on benefactors to sponsor a classroom set of 30 books. With each set comes a curriculum guide created by teachers and tailored to state-mandated academic standards. For more information about becoming a K4K classroom sponsor, email info@wildlifeinfocus.org

FROM THE BOARD

Welcome to Wildlife in Focus XIII, which displays a stunning collection of photographs that celebrates the biodiversity of the Texas environment, the mission commitments and efforts from all participants, and the artistic skills of the 2025 Wildlife in Focus contest winners.

The Wildlife in Focus Board of Directors extends its deepfelt appreciation to all the participating landowner-photographer teams. The dedication, vision, and talent reflected in the work across these pages makes these images as insightful as they are spectacular.

We hope this collection of photographs showcasing Texas wildlife and the landscapes in which it flourishes will inspire others to join us in preserving our natural environment for generations to come.

BOARD OF DIRECTORS 2026

Bill Weekley – *President*
Shelbi Stark – *Vice President*
David Veltri – *Treasurer*
Cody Mazur – *Secretary*
Cissy Beasley
John Carter
Darrel Cochran
Dr. Sandy Hurwitz
Claire Vaughan

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Michelle Orcutt – *Past President*

STAFF

Christi Morales – *Office Manager/Education Director*
Miles Phillips – *Executive Director*

PEOPLE'S CHOICE

PEOPLE'S CHOICE

2025

Photographer: Martin Parea
Landowner: Clay Neel at JF Welder Heirs

The people's choice award recognized the images selected by the public through online voting that was conducted for two weeks after the main awards event. The top 5 Images were awarded recognition

Bobcat

B04-3-027

Scott Null & Bill Harvey

Dale Land & Cattle, Sick Dog Ranch
Mitchell and Dianne Dale and Michael Dale

First Place - Wild Cats and Bear

PEOPLE'S CHOICE

2025

American Alligator

D05-1-044

Martin Parea

JF Welder Heirs, Clay Neel

First Place - All Other Reptiles and Amphibians: Alligators, Salamanders, Newts and Siren

Blue Indigo Snake

D04-2-027

Scott Null & Bill Harvey

Dale Land & Cattle - Sick Dog Ranch - Mitchell and Dianne Dale and Michael Dale

First Place - Snakes

Brown Crested Flycatcher

A08-2-053

Emmanuel Marquez & Brian Vogt

Eshleman Vogt and Balderas Ranch - Brian Vogt

Third Place - Flycatchers and Kingbirds, Phoebes, and Pewees

Bobcat

B04-2-027

Scott Null & Bill Harvey

Dale Land & Cattle - Sick Dog Ranch - Mitchell and Dianne Dale and Michael Dale

Third Place - Wild Cats and Bear

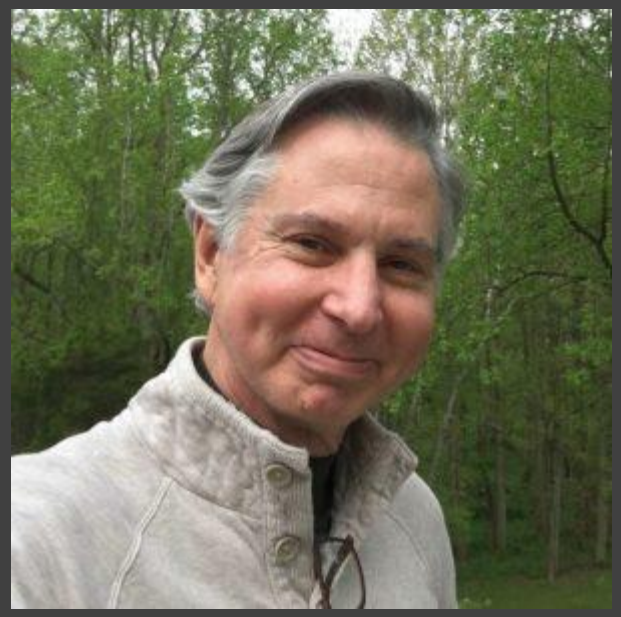
MAMMALS DIVISION

"The Earth is what we all have in common."
— Wendell Berry

2025 Wildlife IN FOCUS

MEET THE JUDGES

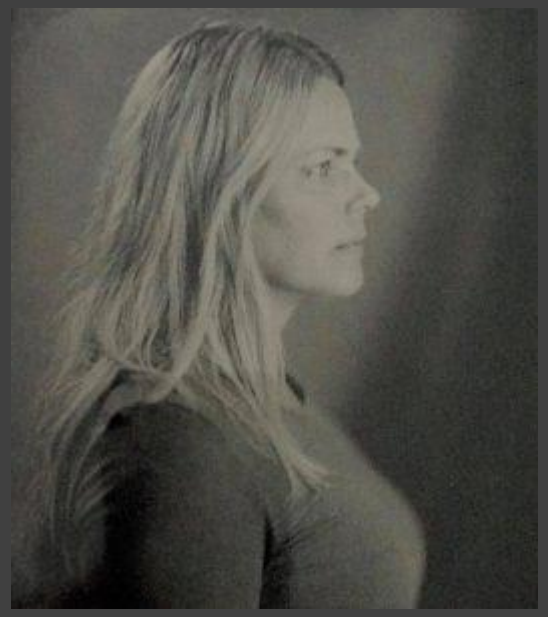
The judges analyzed, discussed, and evaluated 4,000 images over a four-day period, in a carefully devised double-blind judging process. This task was cheerfully undertaken by our panel of eminently qualified judges. Our heartfelt thanks go out to each of our judges for generously donating their time, talent, and skill.



Stephen B. Freligh
Nature's Best Photography, Publisher, and Editor-in-Chief

Steve Freligh is co-publisher of the award-winning magazine, Nature's Best Photography, and has more than 25 years of experience in the photo publishing industry, including projects with Discovery Communications, the National Geographic Society, the National Wildlife Federation, Smithsonian Institution, and more.

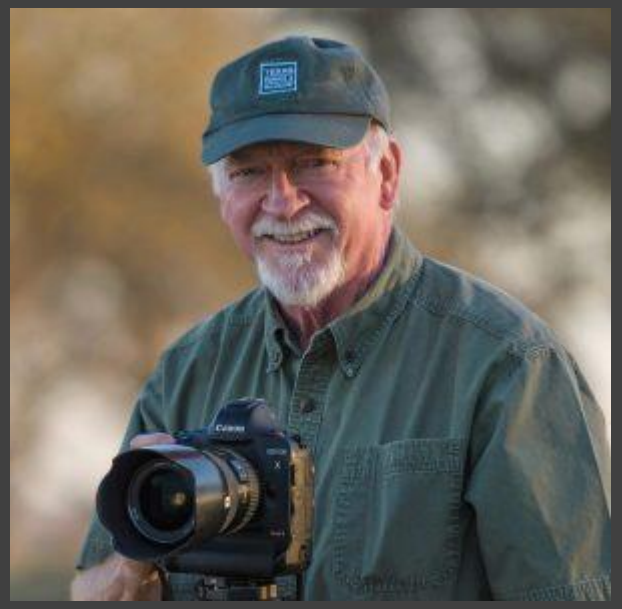
Steve is also Director of the annual Nature's Best Photography Windland Smith Rice International Awards competition and curator of the associated print exhibition at the Smithsonian's National Museum of Natural History.
www.NaturesBestPhotography.com



Sonja Sommerfeld
TPWD Photo Editor

Sonja Sommerfeld has been a professional photographer since the 2000s. Photographing musicians and creating photographic fine art in Austin started her career while she was attending university. After obtaining her undergrad in marketing and fine arts, she worked for the associated press, industrial industry and several well-known local photographers.

Being an assisted for Dan Winters during that time, spurred her to go to graduate school to master her techniques as well as become proficient in large format captures. After years of advertising photography, Sonja transitioned into photographically telling wildlife and adventure stories. Eleven years ago, she joined the Texas Parks & Wildlife magazine team where she is currently the photo editor and photographer for the magazine.



Earl Nottingham
Professional Photographer

Earl Nottingham is a Texas-based photographer whose work spans over 45 years, including the past 25 years for the Texas Parks & Wildlife department where he served as chief photographer, documenting the landscape, wildlife and people who tell the story of conservation in the great state.

His work has been showcased in numerous regional and national publications and outlets such as Texas Parks & Wildlife, Texas Highways, Texas Monthly, Smithsonian, National Geographic Traveler and the Associated Press.

Photographic awards include those from Associated Press Managing Editors, Outdoor Writers of America, Association of Conservation Information, International Regional Magazine Association as well as a Regional Emmy Award. His book, "Wild Focus", is a 25-year retrospective of his work at Texas Parks & Wildlife.

A HEARTFELT THANK YOU TO...

Claire Vaughan, Past President, and her husband George. Together they hosted Wildlife In Focus events at their Twin Oaks Ranch and provided office space in San Antonio. Much of the reason Wildlife In Focus has been growing and thriving is due to the incredible advocacy and coordinated efforts by Claire Vaughan over the last few years.

As a participating landowner and taking the initiative to serve on the board of directors as President, she led the organization through significant expansion. She recruited new board members, oversaw changes in the contest that transitioned it to a statewide event, and relocated the office to San Antonio. After recruiting new sponsors, she guided the organization in hosting a sold-out awards event at the prestigious Witte Natural History Museum. Her deep passion for the Wildlife In Focus mission and its Kritters 4 Kids program was demonstrated by overseeing updates to the curriculum to align with current Texas educational standards, along with establishing new collaborations with Texas 4-H Youth. Her generosity of time and treasure has helped create a revitalized organization that is adding new photo contests and activities. In addition to these accomplishments, she advanced efforts to honor past participants by completing both the 2021 and 2023 Wildlife In Focus photography books, which were designed and published after delays caused by COVID and cost barriers.

All those that care for Texas wildlife, habitat, and photography can be thankful for Claire Vaughan. And so, from all the board and fans of Texas wildlife and habitat, photographers, and private landowners' stewardship of wildlife, Thank you Claire!

OUR SPONSORS

A donation helps all of Wildlife in Focus efforts including youth education, adult engagement through the photo contests and public awareness of private land conservation.

We wish to extend a heartfelt "thank you" to our Sponsors who help to make the photography contest and the 2025 Wildlife in Focus XIII, possible through their generous gifts to the Coastal Bend Wildlife Habitat Education Program.

EDUCATION PROGRAM

Kritters 4 Kids (K4K) is Wildlife In Focus's environmental education program based on Wildlife In Focus books. What began as a way to introduce school children to the wild world has evolved into a classroom curriculum supplement that fulfills state-mandated testing guidelines. Today, K4K is taught in more than 230 schools statewide. Our mission is simple: Inspire a connection between students and the ecoregions of Texas while introducing them to native plants and wildlife so the next generation embraces its role in conservation.

We achieve this goal through the support and generosity of our Angels for Education foundations, corporations, clubs, and grandparents. These partners are crucial to our mission. They fund curriculum development, school sponsorships, and summer camps.

We thank you all.

A few Angels for Education have been with us for years. The Ed Rachel Foundation is our founding partner. In 2001, the foundation recognized something valuable and worthwhile in what we do, so they funded the creation of our original curriculum.

The Harvey Weil Foundation is another godsend. For years, they have generously provided matching grant funds for

We are what we put into this world. Each of us has a choice in how we spend our time, energy, and money. The support of our Angels for Education is the lifeblood of Wildlife in Focus and its mission. Please consider helping us make a difference. Sponsor a school, offer a scholarship for a camper, and become an Angel for Education today!

We can also be found at https://kritters4kids.org/

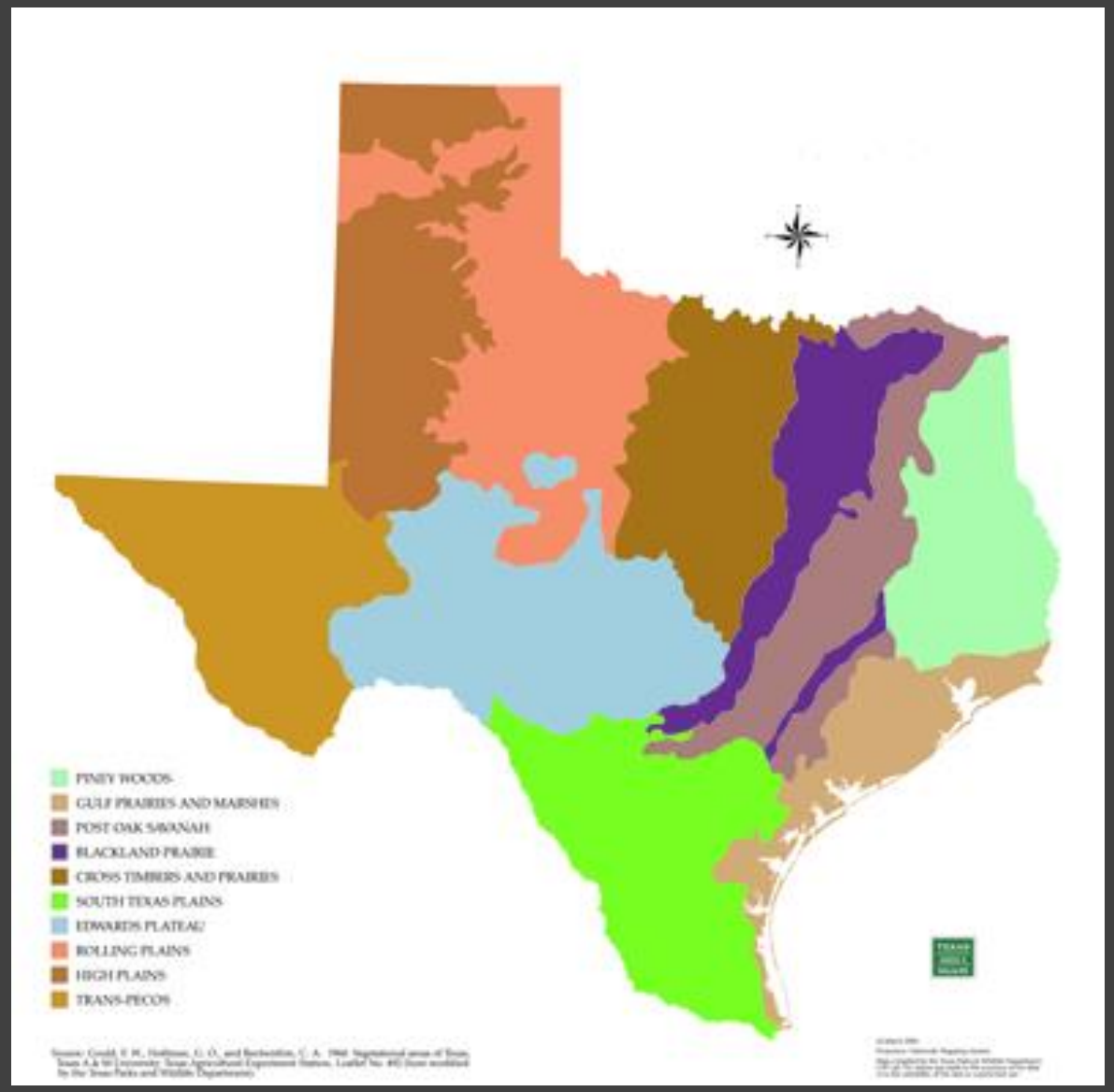
Gulf Coast Toad

Cissy Beasley

El Sueno Ranch - Amanda Sasser

Second Place - Frogs and Toads

ECOLOGY OF TEXAS



https://tpwd.texas.gov/education/hunter-education/online-course/wildlife-conservation/texas-ecoregions#:~:text=Generally%2C%20Texas%20is%20divided%20into,%2C%20and%20the%20Trans-Pecos.

"Due to its size and geographic location, Texas is unique among states. Covering 266,807 sq. miles, it is second only to Alaska in land area. A large area of land will usually have a great deal of variation in climate and landscapes, factors influencing habitat diversity. The state has impressive topographic diversity, including 91 mountain peaks that are a mile or more high.

Our geographic location is a crossroads where eastern habitats meet western ones and southern subtropical habitats meet northern temperate ones. The annual rainfall can range from eight inches in the deserts of far west Texas to 56 inches per year in the swamps of east Texas.

Generally, Texas is divided into 10 natural regions or ecoregions: the Piney Woods, the Gulf Prairies and marshes, the Post Oak Savanah, the Blackland Prairies, the Cross Timbers, the South Texas Plains, the Edwards Plateau, the Rolling Plains, the High Plains, and the Trans-Pecos."

INDEX OF LANDOWNERS

Wildlife in Focus extends its appreciation to the landowners and photographers whose partnership and dedication make this conservation effort possible. Through a stewardship of over half a million acres of land, landowners commit to documenting over 600 species of wildlife in their natural habitats, which plays a vital role in preserving Texas biodiversity for future generations.

Property	Landowners	Photographers
1-20 Wildlife Preserve	Wes Faris	Matthew Furst
3C Joppa Cattle Co at Bryson Ranch	Jeff Charlton	Cheri Freeman
Anthony C Ranch	Kate and John Park	Kate Park
Black Bull Ranch	Scott Schreiner Parker	John W. Parker
Block Creek Nature Area	Sharron and Larry Jay	Kathy Adams Clark
Blucher House	Monika Page	Jason David Page
BQ 5 Ranch and Nature Retreat	Wilfred Korth	Scott Rush
Broken Barr Ranch	Sam and Connie Barr	Connie Barr
Brown Ranch	Charles and Diann Brown	Amanda Snowden, Edgar De La Garza
Cartwright Forest	Bryan Cartwright	Sean Fleming
Chestnut Ranch	Keleigh and Stuart Sasser	Jeff Birmingham
Circle T Ranch	John Edgerley	Saskia Vaughan
Cool Water Ranch	Nancy Bowermaster	Joseph Lucas
Cornelius Ranches	John and Donna Cornelius	Thomas Stinson, Rick Harding
Cuatro Venadas 4X	Kristin and David Held	Sergina M Flaherty
Dale Land & Cattle - Sick Dog Ranch	Mitchell and Dianne Dale and Michael Dale	Scott Null, Bill Harvey
Diamond V Ranch, Inc.	Stephen Goebel	William A. Aiken
Diamond V Ranch, Inc.	Stephen Goebel	William Weekley
Downie Ranch	ADRanch LLC - Downie Mickler	Nick Kanakis
El Potrero Ranch	David and Eline Haunschild	Hugh Lieck
El Sauz Ranch, East Foundation	James Powell	Christian von Preysing
El Sueno Ranch	Amanda Sasser	Cissy Beasley
Eshleman Vogt and Balderas Ranch	Brian Vogt	Emmanuel Marquez, Brian Vogt
Fennessey Ranch	Katie Swanson	Charles Seidel
Hemphill Land & Cattle, LLC	Joe Pat Hemphill	Maxine Hemphill
Hoffman Rocking H Ranches, Ltd.	Bruce P Hoffman	Rick Vogels
Houston Audubon Sanctuaries	Pete Deichmann	Scott Buckel
Hudspeth River Ranch	Alice Ball Strunk	Mary Candee
JF Welder Heirs	Clay Neel	Martin Parea
Jones Alta Vista Ranch	Kevin Avery	Steve DuPre'
Jones-Simonson Ranch	Jeanene S. Jones	Sylvia A. Garcia-Smith, Laura Campbell
Kenedy Memorial Foundation	Marco Castillo	Daniel Woolsey
Kincaid Ranch	Buzz (William) Kincaid	David Pruitt Jr.

INDEX OF LANDOWNERS

Continued…

Property	Landowners	Photographers
Kirchoff Prairie	Don Kirchoff	Rachel LaCoss, Silas Acosta
Knolle Jersey Farms	John Robert Pettigrove	Jonathan Wickham, Luke Markert
La Lomita Wildlife Photography Ranch	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	Laura Lee Barfield
La Lomita Wildlife Photography Ranch #2	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	Israel Alapag, Mark Luther
Laborcitas Creek Ranch	Charles Lawrence	Charles Lawrence, Aron (Benny) Cantu
Lagarto Creek Ranch, Cypress Creek Ranch, Palmetto Ventures Ranch	Jeff and Cindy Kirby	Jon Reinhard
Lagarto Ranch	Gus Cargile III	Garry Turnquist
Los Novios Ranch/ Twin Oaks	George and Claire Vaughan	Walton Cude
Los Robles	John Lee	Cissy Beasley
Monte Verde Ranch	Jason Brummerhop	James Quisenberry, Tony Morano
Mount Lucas Ranch	Leonidas Cartwright	Julie Cartwright, Loncito Cartwright
Oso Bilando	Elizabeth Rachael Carr	Shelbi Stark
Phoinix Ranch	Scott and Elizabeth Reeves	Reynaldo Garza
Ray Ranch Bonny View	Robin and Sydney Orchard	Nicole Reagan
Redlands Ranch	Russell Graves	Barry Lambert, Russell Graves
Roam Ranch	Taylor Collins	Anthony Lemley
Rob and Bessie Welder Wildlife Foundation	Dale James	Angie Birmingham
Rolling Plains Quail Research Ranch	Ryan O'Shaughnessy	Katy Hoskins, Emily Thornock
Santa Clara Ranch	Claire and Beto Gutierrez	Hector D. Astorga
Santa Cruz Ranch	Eric J Garza	Eric J Garza
Sea Dan Ranch	Kathleen Carey	Leslie Natale
Serendipity	Kevin and Shelly Nelson	William Colson, Ashlynn Colson
Sid Williams Ranch	Sidney Johnston Williams IV	Jacob Williams, Jeremy Dipner
The Pig & Fig	Nathan and Heidi Wilshusen	Shelbi Stark, Chris Stark
Thomson T Circle Ranch		Julia Lane, Jim Lane
Todd Vineyard	Susan Shown Todd	David Veltri, Rick Moore
Transition Ranch	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	Sandy Hurwitz, Kelley Ahr
Transition Ranch #2	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	Daniel Gomez, Mark Deschner
Transition Ranch #3	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	John Chitty, Johnny Campbell
Transition Ranch #4	Dr Sandy Hurwitz	Jami Linder
Weaver Family Ranches	Susan Weaver	Joe Villarreal, Michael Cantu
Wishbone Ranch	Richard Shimer, Brandon Shimer, David De La Cruz	Darrell Cochran, Susan Cochran
Zynaida Farms	Ken and Barbara Bung	Kendra Colson, Brianna Colson

PUBLISHED BY

Wildlife in Focus

Book:
Wildlife in Focus XIII 2025

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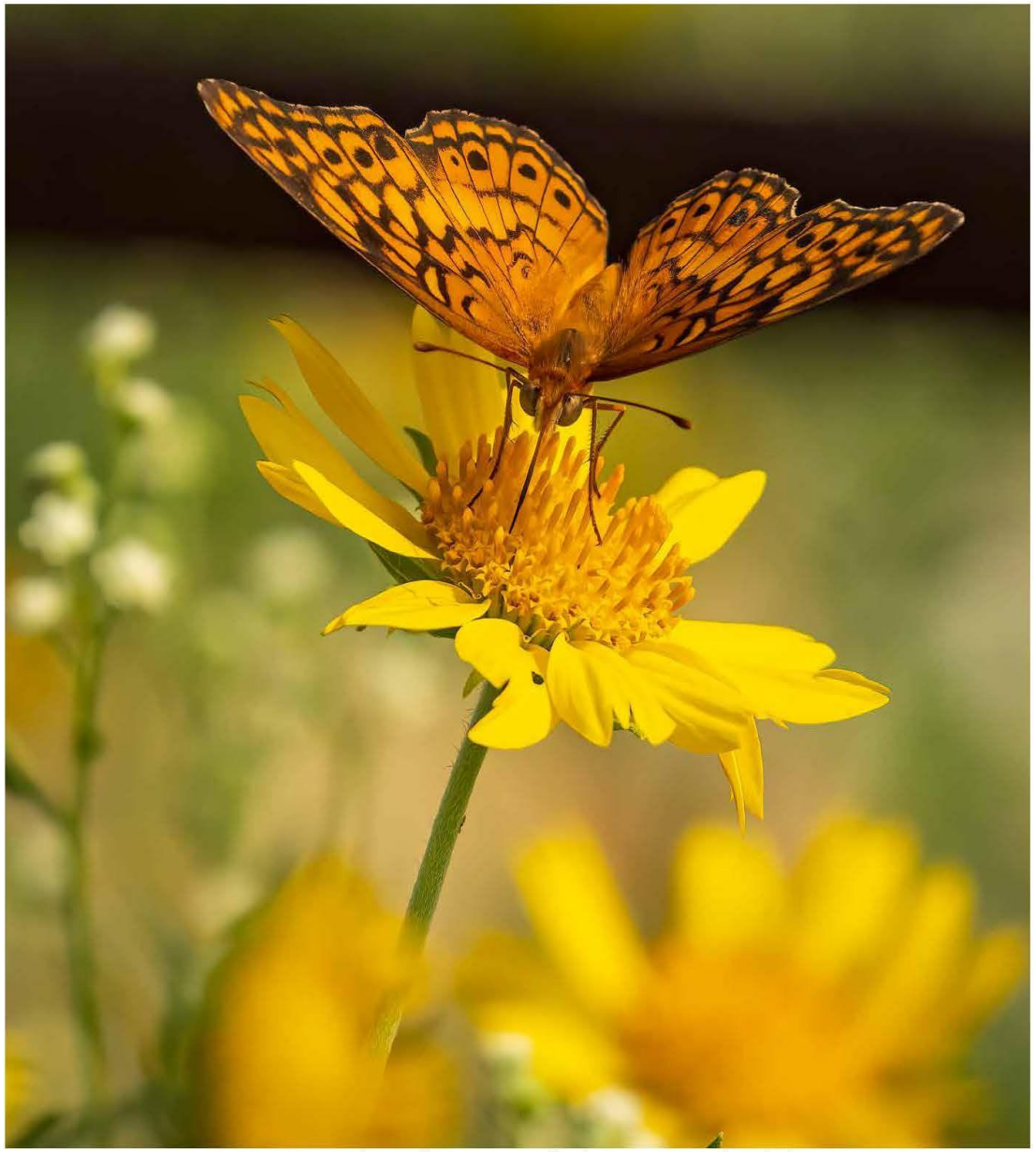

Variegated Fritillary Butterfly (Euptoieta claudia) C01-3-026

To the Community:

Become more connected to the natural world through engaging educational resources. Winning photographs are featured in books, magazines, and our traveling Benefactor's Photo Exhibit, showcased in sponsoring businesses, museums, art centers, and special events.

Reynaldo Garza

Phoenix Ranch – Scott and Elizabeth Reeves

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WILDLIFE IN FOCUS XIII

THE THIRTEENTH BIENNIAL

WILDLIFE IN FOCUS CONTEST

PHOTOGRAPHY AS ART

Painted Bunting

A15-1-039

Connie Barr

Broken Barr Ranch - Sam and Connie Barr

First Place - Buntings, Cardinals, Pyrrhuloxias and Hummingbirds

Book Patrons

100 Books

80 Books

50 Books

20 Books

The sale of this book goes to promote wildlife and habitat conservation in Texas.